

THEN A deserted Sadar Bazaar, the wholesale market in Old Delhi, Apr. 20, 2021

At the LNJP Hospital in Delhi, once the capital's largest Covid facility with 1,500 reserved beds, only two patients occupy the now 450-bed Covid ward. Their complaint? A sore throat—they are in hospital on account of their age: both are over 65 years old. Only a year and some months ago, in May 2021, when India was in the grip of a deadly Delta wave, this same hospital was bursting at the seams. So much so that even its lift lobbies, classrooms and OPDs had become makeshift emergency rooms. Not any more.

A spirit of liberation is in the air. No one is wearing masks any more, the markets are full, people are travelling and social distancing is beginning to sound like an anachronism. Everyone is gearing up for Diwali, the first time since 2019 that they will be celebrating the festive season without the sword of Covid hanging over their heads. It's not as though the virus has disappeared, just that patient and doctor alike are not afraid of Covid any more. "I prescribe no more than rest and maybe a paracetamol. That is enough for the disease today," says Dr Sushila Kataria, internal medicine specialist at Medanta – The Medicity, Gurugram, and the first to treat a Covid patient in the state.

The world has been waiting for an official declaration of the end of the pandemic, but the World Health Organization (WHO) said Covid-19 remains a global health emergency as recently as on October 19. A month earlier, US president Joe Biden declared the pandemic over, but with fresh mutations like BF.7 and XBB rearing their head, the country has had to extend its status as a public health emergency by another 90 days. Europe, too, seems resigned to living with Covid and has reintroduced the mask mandate. Singapore likewise had downgraded Covid's status to endemic in July but is seeing an XBB surge.

And back home? Noted virologist Dr Gagandeep Kang says, "You could argue that the pandemic phase has been over for about six months in India. We have not seen any major hospitalisations or surges," she says. On October 14, only 44 Covid beds stood occupied in the entire capital. In Kerala, the state with the highest number of Covid cases, 90 per cent of the hospital beds lie empty and out of 4,773 patients on October 14, only 1 per cent exhibited severe symptoms. The country saw eight deaths on the same date, compared to nearly three deaths per minute at the height of the surge in May 2021. The fact that daily deaths have been restricted to less than 70 for six months now leads Dr N.K. Arora, chairman of the National Covid-19 Task Force, to declare, "We are currently in a relatively comfortable, happy position in the country as far as Covid is concerned."

The change is reflected in the numbers too. On October 6 this year, India had 32,282 active cases, 2,529 new ones and nine deaths in 24 hours. Contrast this to May 6, 2021, when the country recorded 3,566,398 active cases, 414,000 new ones and 3,915 deaths in a single day; the previous year, on September 14, 2020, India saw 989,167 active cases, 83,809 new ones and 1,054 deaths. Even globally, daily deaths due to Covid have hovered around 2,000 on average in the past six months. On October 15, this figure was 661, compared to 13,230 deaths in a day at the height of the first wave, 14,423 in the second wave and 11,987 in the third.

What's changed? Have the multiple mutations enervated